fireworks, with TV news channels devoting prime time to the "crisis in the CPI(M)". The old nepotism debates, flashy lifestyles and shady dealings of a number of comrades were once again dissected. EP's cohorts have not been sitting idle either, hitting back with selective leaks about P. Jayarajan's alleged links to the gold smuggling racket and "goonda gangs" in Kannur.

The state opposition has been gleefully watching Pinarayi and company squirm in the media glare, though many of the leaders have refused to join issue saying it is an "internal matter of the party". The recently concluded CPI(M) politburo meeting also did not discuss the matter, but sources say the central committee directed its state counterpart to "initiate appropriate steps". EP, who had been MIA politically for the past three months, finally surfaced before the state secretariat on December 30 to offer an explanation. He apparently told the committee that he had no stake in the ayurveda resort although his family has invested Rs 93 lakh in it. He claims that wife Indira, who retired as general manager of Kannur District Cooperative Bank, and his son Jaison, an NRI, have invested in the project with their earnings.

Pinarayi has now called for a truce and directed all those involved to settle the issue without further damaging the party's image. He knows he can't afford a divide in the party ranks in home base Kannur, especially when he commands the only CPI(M)-led government in the country. C.P. John, state secretary of the Communist Marxist Party (CMP), a breakaway faction of the CPI(M), is scathing about his old party's plans for "rectification". "How can the state CPI(M) do any such thing when the party is a repository of goons and smugglers? The corrupt can never be true communists. The Kerala unit will end up going the Bengal way," he says. ■



SOMETHING FOR THEM People at a rally in Bilaspur, Chhattisgarh, in 2018. The state government has hiked quota to 76 per cent in jobs and educational institutions in December

CHHATTISGARH

THE RESERVATIO

By Rahul Noronha

Chhattisgarh's complex caste equations are at the centre of a pitched political battle between the BJP and Congress in the run-up to the 2023 assembly polls. The core issue: enhanced reservation for marginalised groups in government jobs and admission to educational institutions. The Bhupesh Baghel-led Congress government has upped the ante by proposing a massive 76 per cent reservation; the BJP has termed it an eyewash. Moreover, Governor Anusuiya Uikey is yet to give her assent to it. Increased reservation might yield dividends in the assembly polls, but there is a catch—more reservation percentages for some groups come at the cost of certain others, thereby complicating matters. The issue also has a bearing on the pro-OBC push both the Congress and the BJP have been pursuing for a couple of years.

Like its parent state Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh had adopted 50 per cent reservation in government jobs and educational institutions, with Scheduled Tribes (STs) getting 20 per cent, Scheduled Castes (SCs) 16 per cent and Other Backward Classes (OBCs) 14 per cent. In 2012, the Raman Singh-led BJP government hiked reservation to 58 per cent, increasing quota for STs to 32 per cent, reducing that for SCs from 16 to 12 per cent and retaining OBC quota at 14 per cent. The main gainers, thus, were the STs. That government claimed this was done on the basis of the 2011 Census that pegged the ST population of Chhattisgarh at around the